The Bell Jar

By Sylvia Plath

INTRODUCTION

The Bell Jar by Sylvia Plath tells the story of a gifted young woman's mental breakdown beginning during a summer internship as a junior editor at a magazine in New York City in the early 1950s. The real Plath committed suicide in 1963 and left behind this scathingly sad, honest and perfectly-written book, which remains one of the best-told tales of a woman's descent into insanity. In this selection, Esther is engaged in a conversation with Joan, another mentally disturbed young woman who seems to idolize Esther for her suicide attempt.

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Joan's room, with its closet and bureau and table and chair and white blanket with the big blue C on it, was a mirror image of my own. It occurred to me that Joan, hearing where I was, had engaged a room at the asylum on pretense, simply as a joke. That would explain why she had told the nurse I was her friend. I had never known Joan, except at a cool distance.

"How did you get here?" I curled up on Joan's bed.

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"I read about you," Joan said.

"What?"

"I read about you, and I ran away."

"How do you mean?" I said evenly.

"Well," Joan leaned back in the chintz-flowered asylum armchair, "I had a summer job working for the chapter head of some fraternity, like the Masons, you know, but not the Masons, and I felt terrible. I had these bunions, I could hardly walk -- in the last days I had to wear rubber boots to work, instead of shoes, and you can imagine what that did to my morale . . ."

I thought either Joan must be crazy-wearing rubber boots to work-or she must be trying to see how crazy I was, believing all that. Besides, only old people ever got bunions. I decided to pretend I thought she was crazy, and that I was only humoring her along . . . '

"I always feel lousy without shoes," I said with an ambiguous smile. "Did your feet hurt much?"

"Terribly. And my boss-he'd just separated from his wife, he couldn't come right out and get a divorce, because that wouldn't go with this fraternal order - my boss kept buzzing me in every other minute, and each time I moved

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my feet hurt like the devil, but the second I'd sit down at my desk again, buzz went the buzzer, and he'd have something else he wanted to get off his chest . . ."

"Why didn't you quit?"

"Oh, I did quit, more or less. I stayed off work on sick leave. I didn't go out. I didn't see anyone. I stowed the telephone in a drawer and never answered it . . .

"Then my doctor sent me to a psychiatrist at this big hospital. I had an appointment for twelve o'clock, and I was in an awful state. Finally, at half past twelve, the receptionist came out and told me the doctor had gone to lunch. She asked me if I wanted to wait, and I said yes."

"Did he come back?" The story sounded rather involved for Joan to have made it up out of whole cloth, but I led her on, to see what would come of it.

"Oh yes. I was going to kill myself, mind you. I said, 'If this doctor doesn't do the trick, that's the end.' Well, the receptionist led me down a long hall, and just as we got to the door, she turned to me and said, 'You don't mind if there are a few students with the doctor, do you?' What could I say? 'Oh no,' I said. I walked in and found nine pairs of eyes fixed on me. Nine! Eighteen separate eyes.

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"Now, if that receptionist had told me there were going to be nine people in that room, I'd have walked out on the spot. But there I was, and it was too late to do a thing about it. Well, on this particular day I happened to be wearing a fur coat . . ."

"In August?"

"Oh, it was one of those cold, wet days, and I thought, my first psychiatrist you know. Anyway, this psychiatrist kept eyeing that fur coat the whole time I talked to him; and I could just see what he thought of my asking to pay the students' cut rate instead of the full fee. I could see the dollar signs in his eyes. Well, I told him I don't know whatall -- about the bunions and the telephone in the drawer and how I wanted to kill myself-and then he asked me to wait outside while he discussed my case with the others, and when he called me back in, you know what he said?"

"What?"

"He folded his hands together and looked at me and said, 'Miss Gilling, we have decided that you would benefit by group therapy."

"Group therapy?" I thought I must sound phony as an echo chamber, but Joan didn't pay any notice.

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"That's what he said. Can you imagine me wanting to kill myself, and coming round to chat about it with a whole pack of strangers, and most of them no better than myself . . ."

"That's crazy." I was growing involved in spite of myself. "That's not even human."

"That's just what I said. I went straight home and wrote that doctor a letter. I wrote him one beautiful letter about how a man like that had no business setting himself up to help sick
people. . ."

"Did you get any answer?"

"I don't know. That was the day I read about you."

"How do you mean?"

"Oh," Joan said, "about how the police thought you were dead and all. I've got a pile of clippings somewhere." She heaved herself up, and I had a strong horsey whiff that made my nostrils prickle. Joan had been a champion horse-jumper at the annual college gymkhana, and I wondered if she had been sleeping in a stable.

Joan rummaged in her open suitcase and came up with a fistful of clippings. "Here, have a look."

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The first clipping showed a big, blown-up picture of a girl with black shadowed eyes and black lips spread in a grin. I couldn't imagine where such a tarty picture had been taken until I noticed the Bloomingdale earrings and the Bloomingdale necklace glinting out of it with bright, white highlights, like imitation stars.

SCHOLARSHIP GIRL MISSING.

MOTHER WORRIED.

The article under the picture told how this girl had disappeared from her home on August 17th, wearing a green skirt and a white blouse, and had left a note saying she was taking a long walk. When Miss Greenwood had not returned by midnight, it said, her mother called the town police.

The next clipping showed a picture of my mother and brother and me grouped together in our backyard and smiling. I couldn't think who had taken that picture either, until I saw I was wearing dungarees and white sneakers and remembered that was what I wore in my spinach-picking summer, and how Dodo Conway had dropped by and taken some family snaps of the three of us one hot afternoon.

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Mrs. Greenwood asked that this picture be printed in hopes that it will encourage her daughter to return home.

SLEEPING PILLS FEARED MISSING WITH GIRL

A dark, midnight picture of about a dozen moon-faced people in a wood. I thought the people at the end of the row looked queer and unusually short until I realized they were not people, but dogs. Bloodhounds used in search for missing girl. Police Sgt. Bill Hindly says: It doesn't look good.

GIRL FOUND ALIVE!

The last picture showed policemen lifting a long, limp blanket roll with a featureless cabbage head into the back of an ambulance. Then it told how my mother had been down in the cellar, doing the week's laundry, when she heard faint groans coming from a disused hole . . .

I laid the clippings on the white spread of the bed.

"You keep them," Joan said. "You ought to stick them in a scrapbook." I folded the clippings and slipped them in my pocket.

"I read about you," Joan went on. "Not how they found you, but everything up to that, and I put all my money together and took the first plane to New York."

"Why New York?"

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"Oh, I thought it would be easier to kill myself in New York."

"What did you do?"

Joan grinned sheepishly and stretched out her hands, palm up. Like a miniature mountain range, large, reddish weals upheaved across the white flesh of her wrists.

"How did you do that?" For the first time it occurred to me Joan and I might have something in common.

"I shoved my fists through my roommate's window."

“My old college roommate. She was working in New York, and I couldn't think of any place else to stay, and besides, I'd hardly any money left, so I went to stay with her. My parents found me there-she'd written them I was acting funny-and my father flew straight down and brought me back."

"But you're all right now." I made it a statement.

Joan considered me with her bright, pebble-gray eyes. "I guess so," she said. "Aren't you?"

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